It was a very satisfying feeling to bat through the innings. It was a big match but we decided not to celebrate too much because the second final in Brisbane was only a day away and we knew it was going to be tough because of the high humidity.

I could not sleep a wink that night and ached all over. The pain in my groin had increased and I was starting to get scared. The next morning I could barely walk and it was an ordeal boarding the early-morning flight. In Brisbane I was given a long massage as soon as we reached the hotel. Seeing my condition, Dhoni suggested that maybe I should miss the second final and play in the third if needed. I said to him that '*Sher jab gira hua hota hai use tabhi mar do*' (When a tiger is down and out, just finish it off. Don't give it a second chance.) He agreed with me that it would be better to close out the competition in Brisbane if we could.

CB Series, second final, Brisbane, 4 March 2008

When we arrived at the Gabba we found that there was a lot of moisture in the pitch. It was bound to be difficult for batting early on and the obvious plan was to field first if we won the toss – but I urged Dhoni not to do so. I reckoned that the Australians might well want to bat first, preferring to bat without the pressure of chasing a target. I thought it would be better if we set a target, even if it meant struggling through the initial period of dampness on the wicket.

Dhoni agreed and we batted first. Again, I told Robin Uthappa in no uncertain terms not to risk a single expansive shot till we had played out the first ten overs. In those conditions not losing wickets was far more important than trying to score runs. Robin successfully held back and we survived the first twenty overs intact, giving us a solid foundation to launch an assault. We then scored at almost six runs an over and ended up with 258, a reasonable score to defend in the circumstances.

I was pleased to score 91, but by the end of the innings I also knew that my body was in bad shape and if we weren't able to win in Brisbane I would be in no condition to play the third final. In fact, I was forced to leave the field in the fourth over of the Australia innings, when Dhoni dived to catch Hayden off Sreesanth and the ball ricocheted and hit me exactly where I had been hit by the Lee beamer.

Meanwhile our opening bowler Praveen Kumar produced a great spell and picked up three crucial Australian wickets. Hayden and Symonds